

Interviewer: Thank you for taking the time to participate in this interview. So, my name is [Interviewer], and as part of this research, we are studying individuals' feelings in various contexts. What we're particularly interested in are romantic relationships, but especially your impressions, personal experiences, and feelings on the subject. What's important to know is that there really are no right or wrong answers. What I'm interested in is simply your feelings. So, let's start. How would you like us to refer to your partner?

Interviewee: [PARTNER]

Interviewer: [PARTNER]. How long have you been with [PARTNER]?

Interviewee: It's been [1-5 years], [1-5] months, and [10-15] days (laughs).

Interviewer: That's precise! (Laughs)

Interviewee: We enjoy counting the days.

Interviewer: I'd like you to tell me about this love story, this relationship you're currently in. So, how did you meet, how did it develop, and all that?

Interviewee: So, we met [1-5 years], [1-5] months, and a little over [10-15] days (laughs). We met in the [setting], I was part of a [group], and she was part of a [association]. We found ourselves in meetings together, and then we started chatting (laughs). Ah yes, I remember the first time we talked, but she says it was another time. It was at this meeting, actually, I do a lot of feminist collages, and she said, "I can get lots of sheets from my job if you want," and she says that we had already talked at a demonstration a bit earlier. After that, for a few weeks, we kept meeting at feminist events. Ah yes, the story is also that at that time, I was seeing another girl; it was recent, we hadn't really defined... we weren't really together, you could say. And actually, [PARTNER] had kind of hooked up with a girl from my collective, which I knew, so before trying anything with [PARTNER], I asked my friend if it was okay with her. She said, "Yes, no problem." And then we kept meeting at various events. She started coming... I was part of a feminist percussion group, so she came, and during my rehearsals, we just kept looking at each other; we could mutually feel that there was something. And then one evening... Actually, after a rehearsal, I was going to a concert, and I invited her and a friend, and... I was supposed to spend the evening with my friends, but I ended up spending the whole evening with her. We kissed, we went to her place. After that, we spent the night together. I don't know if I should continue, do you want more details?

Interviewer: Was it from that moment on that you considered yourselves a couple? Or did it take a little more time after that?

Interviewee: Well, at the beginning... actually, during that period, I told her that I was seeing another girl, and she said, "Oh yes, no problem." Actually, when we started being together, neither of us thought we would really be in a relationship. It was more "just like that." It's true that we were quite different. At that time, I didn't want to be in a relationship at all, so I saw it

more as, "we'll see each other, and as always at the beginning, we say 'yeah, let's not overthink it,' we'll just see each other and that's it." But quite quickly, she said, "yeah, no problem if you see other girls," but I already felt that I had a lot of feelings for [PARTNER], so I didn't really want to see the other girl anymore, so I didn't see her again on my own. But later, she confessed that it actually bothered her that I was seeing other girls, but she hadn't told me. And quite quickly, it was just before the first lockdown, so I know the beginning was quite complicated. We fought a lot, already. She, at that time... I don't like saying it like this, it sounds like I'm blaming her, but she was very... she had a lot of anxieties, fears of abandonment, things like that, I was in a phase where I didn't know how to reassure and I didn't want to. I didn't want to owe anything. So quickly... I had fears of losing my freedom, and she, conversely, of being abandoned. So we fought quite strongly. And at the beginning, I told her at least twice, "I don't want to continue," and she insisted, saying "no, but we can make it work..." so well, she was right (laughs). But, let's say that the whole first year was kind of like that. But, by working on ourselves, she worked a lot on her anxieties... so she started asking less of me, and I explained to her what she needed to feel reassured. I think we grew together.

Interviewer: From the beginning, you weren't on the same wavelength, but in the end, you persevered, whereas many other people would have given up. What motivated you to keep going, even though there were some early conflicts?

Interviewee: Pffffff, honestly, you'd have to take the answer she gave. As for me... I accepted, but I was more passive in it. She insisted, there were several times when I wanted to end the relationship because I thought it was impossible, it was too hard for me to do that work, and I could never give her what she needed, plus I wasn't doing well at that time, so it didn't help. I told her to let it go. During the period when I was depressed, I told her we should stop, and she said it was her choice, she wanted to be with me, so I said okay.

Interviewer: So it wasn't just about you. It was also about your mental health and everything else...

Interviewee: Yeah. Yeah, it doesn't help. Mental health is connected to everything else. But there's also the context. I'm still studying, but it's quite demanding; my depression, I think, was more like burnout depression. I think when you're working a lot, it doesn't help at all in building a relationship; you don't have the time or energy.

Interviewer: You have less time for yourself, to focus on yourself and work on yourself.

Interviewee: Yeah, that's it. And even less for a relationship. And for her, since she had a lot of needs, if we didn't see each other for [1-5] days, she felt really bad... So, all these things made me say it wasn't possible, I had too much work, I couldn't give her all that. And that's what made me say, "it's not going to work."

Interviewer: It added a mental load, in a way.

Interviewee: I learned a lot about how to reassure her, to be more serene in my feelings. And she, at the same time, learned to have much fewer expectations of me. All of this makes things better now.

Interviewer: And how long would you say it took to stabilize with all this work on yourselves?

Interviewee: I think... about [1-5] year. About. Sometimes she says, "it's been [1-5] year since you wanted to leave me, so that means things are better" (laughs). I think the last time I wanted to leave her was around [Month]... since then, we hardly ever fight. The relationship is much more stable.

Interviewer: You've found a good balance.

Interviewee: Definitely.

Interviewer: And in terms of the quality of your relationship, if you had to compare it to that of your friends, what would you say?

Interviewee: It's not done to compare (laughs)...

Interviewer: The quality of your relationship compared to the quality, in your opinion, of your friends' relationships, from your point of view.

Interviewee: (Silence). Well, already, I don't have many friends who are in relationships. But, but still, I'd say it's superior. I don't know who to compare myself to. If I compare it to the more traditional relationships I know, the hetero ones, I think our relationship is of better quality. After that, I don't really know among my close friends... it's hard.

Interviewer: And you would say it's superior in what way? In which area, maybe?

Interviewee: In communication. I think it's the basis of any good relationship, so... I'd say that. But that's because I'm comparing it to hetero relationships that aren't great. I don't know, actually, it's hard because I don't know who to compare it to.

Interviewer: Okay. And even compared to heterosexual relationships, there would be communication. Is there anything else?

Interviewee: Uh, I think it's related, but being able to be completely oneself and honest about who we are, what we feel, it goes with communication but it's maybe different.

Interviewer: Being natural, in a way.

Interviewee: Being able to show oneself as we are, not hiding things, not all couples manage to do that. Even in intimacy, of the body... well, I don't know. Actually, I don't talk much about that with other people.

Interviewer: But a kind of freedom, perhaps. Free to be oneself, to say what we want... And if you had to compare with your previous relationships?

Interviewee: (Laughs). That's not done either. Well, it's the best relationship I've ever had in my life.

Interviewer: Could you say in what way?

Interviewee: Well, already the two main points... I think we have... actually, the fact of having... I don't know if we can say love is built but... already it's my longest relationship without breaking up. Like, stable relationship, you could say. And so, I feel like I've developed, over the course of the relationship, a love for [PARTNER] that has grown over time, I feel like I love her deeply, in the person she is, and also being able to project myself... Before her, I had anxiety about projecting myself with someone. I felt oppressed. And now, for almost a year, it doesn't scare me to say... She used to joke, "we'll be together until we're 99," and when she said that I would have anxiety attacks, and now projecting myself, why not... Maybe not in the same way as we have now, but it doesn't scare me to think we could be side by side forever, and I had never thought that before. And... yeah, I think it's these things.

Interviewer: A love with more solid foundations.

Interviewee: Yeah, definitely.

Interviewer: How many partners have you had in total?

Interviewee: Serious partners, as in they were my girlfriend?

Interviewer: Yes.

Interviewee: Can't be bothered to count, but I'd say around [6-10].

Interviewer: And among these [6-10] partners, is it the first time with [PARTNER] that there is less anxiety about losing freedom... and [PARTNER]?

Interviewee: Yeah, it's that I really feel like being myself. Before, I often hid when I wasn't feeling well, things like that. Or played a role too. With [PARTNER], I feel like we're not really playing a role. At least in our relationship... I can be myself.

Interviewer: And I'd like you to talk about what you consider a high-quality relationship.

Interviewee: So, it's related. Being able to be oneself, loving each other in all dimensions, and also accepting one's evolution, and that the other accepts our evolution, and even if we don't evolve in the same way, still loving each other. Being able to talk about everything, not necessarily agreeing on everything, being able to exchange calmly... maybe another thing is not having too many big arguments, I really don't like that. I think it's normal to argue, but not to the extent that it becomes overwhelming and makes us feel bad. Arguing about things is normal,

but knowing that it doesn't take on too much importance. I think as long as we can talk about everything and accept everything, we can do anything. Also being able to question the relationship. Discussing... sometimes for fun we say, "let's talk about our love," and it's to take stock, to know how we still love each other, what we'd like to see evolve... When I can project myself with her, I think it might be another mode of relationship, not exclusive... being able to talk about what we want and finding solutions together.

Interviewer: Taking nothing for granted and questioning oneself, in fact.

Interviewee: Yeah.

Interviewer: And when would you say your relationship was like this? With all these adjectives.

Interviewee: It's hard to say, but it's not very old... Maybe [6-10] months ago. It might also... oh, one thing I didn't say about a quality relationship, I think both people need to have come a long way and know... it requires knowing oneself well and being able to communicate who we are, our needs... so yeah, I'd say [6-10] months ago. It's to say that it goes in parallel with the fact that I have grown, I have come a long way, and [PARTNER]...

Interviewer: But you insist a lot on the point that it is built together, but also and especially, I feel, each person on their own.

Interviewee: Yeah, well, both actually. For me, they really go together. The relationship also allows a lot of questioning of oneself; alone, we ask fewer questions. I think it's in the relationship with others that we build ourselves, and particularly in a romantic relationship because it allows us to experience more things intensely.

Interviewer: And it's more intimate too, less superficial sometimes than a friendship?

Interviewee: Yes, but it depends; some people experience that in friendship too.

Interviewer: True. And when was your relationship the least qualitative?

Interviewee: Yes, yes, frankly, the first year. After that, necessarily, the first months always go too well but don't meet the definition of a quality relationship.

Interviewer: And what are the most important things for you in a romantic relationship?

Interviewee: The same things... (laughs). In truth, everything I said, accepting the other... meeting their needs... I think it's the same things.

Interviewer: What's important in a romantic relationship for you is everything that also corresponds to the quality of the relationship, then.

Interviewee: Yes, exactly.

Interviewer: And based on what you've experienced, I'd like you to talk about what love means to you.

Interviewee: (Laughs). There is no THE definition of love. Love in the singular doesn't mean anything. I think there are many types of love, whether in the relationship with another, the romantic and exclusive relationship... There are several types of love. So, I wouldn't know what to say. To me, it doesn't mean anything.

Interviewer: That is, several types of love?

Interviewee: It's super hard to describe. All these types of love are linked to feelings, and feelings... honestly, I don't know. In fact, when I say there are several types of love, there are even within the relationship with [PARTNER]. I think... the love I feel recently... that's not necessarily love. There are other things... every time I say "I love you" to her, depending on the situations, it has different meanings. I love her for many different things.

Interviewer: So it's an abstract concept that encompasses several branches.

Interviewee: Yeah, yeah, that's it. Within which there is this deep love where I see myself being by her side, maybe all my life, but there are also other things. Even before feeling that, I loved her too. And I think I still love her in other ways than just that thing, I think...

Interviewer: Kind of like the different stages of building love, perhaps.

Interviewee: Yeah, that's it, but they aren't necessarily successive stages. They overlap.

Interviewer: Not successive and progressive stages.

Interviewee: Stages that can overlap and exist at the same time.

Interviewer: And you would say that love is important in a relationship?

Interviewee: Pffffff. For me, or in general?

Interviewer: For you, according to you.

Interviewee: For me, it's super important. Taking into account that it can take different forms. I've never managed to be in a relationship without feeling love. But that's for me; I know that for some people it's not the case.

Interviewer: For you, it's more of a prerequisite without which a relationship would be harder to build?

Interviewee: Yes, but at the same time, we can also talk about love and a friendly relationship.

Interviewer: Completely.

Interviewee: So yes, if I don't feel love, in all its diversity, I won't have a relationship with someone.

Interviewer: We know there are different forms and ways of loving... How do you know your partner loves you?

Interviewee: (Laughs). Well... in what forms... well she tells me she feels this unconditional love... that no matter what I do or what changes I might make, she'll still love me the same. So that's cool. (Laughs).

Interviewer: So she tells you. Are there other ways she shows it to you?

Interviewee: Well, already, she tells me all the time. And the ways she shows it... well, already, she tells me all the time... I don't know, she always gives me hugs, kisses... Well... I think that's mostly it. And when I say she tells me, it's not just "I love you" but also other expressions...

Interviewer: Can you talk about one of the last positive interactions you had with [PARTNER]?

Interviewee: Well, when I saw her earlier today (laughs).

Interviewer: It was a positive interaction in what way?

Interviewee: Well, already, every time we see each other, I think it's positive interactions, and... the last time we saw each other, we... had sex, so that's it. But it's not just that that reflects our relationship in terms of positive interactions. That doesn't happen often. But it just so happens that was it. But there was a 99% chance I'd say something else.

Interviewer: Okay. In any case, that was the last one. And you say that in 99% of cases, you wouldn't have said that. So what else could it have been?

Interviewee: Well... well, every time we see each other. It could be talking, eating together, showing each other things, watching a series... We just came back from vacation, so being on vacation together too.

Interviewer: Can you talk about one of the last negative interactions you had?

Interviewee: Yeah, well, we fought during the vacation. It was a bit annoying. Honestly, it doesn't happen often that we fight, but... actually, our fights are always related to our mental health, which is itself very linked to our hormonal cycles. And we both experience premenstrual syndrome, and I think in everyday life... when I'm not feeling well, I prefer to be alone, and when she's like that, she feels really bad and needs cuddles. But, because I'm not always with [PARTNER]... I think I have more trouble responding to that if we're together 24/7, and on vacation, we were in a not very comfortable situation, camping in the rain, it was a bit annoying, so the fact of not feeling well, we fought over stupid things. And I think being together 24/7 isn't good for us either.

Interviewer: It's true that vacations are a special context, you're together all the time.

Interviewee: Yes, and if there are tensions... here, premenstrual syndromes...

Interviewer: And generally speaking, what are, in your opinion, the challenges to overcome in your relationship?

Interviewee: It's continuing to find compromises to meet both our expectations, like, for example, the lifestyle where we have... like, I'm sure that currently, for at least the next two years, I want to live alone. And she's thinking about buying an apartment... And that's quite a big issue. But I think she also decided that she prefers we don't live together, but it's still a question... also, we talk a lot about maybe one day, later, in a few years, starting a family with a child. That's it.

Interviewer: So the challenges, I feel, concern things that are for a more distant future.

Interviewee: Yeah, that's it, and then in everyday life, it's continuing to find... if there are desires or needs that come up on either side, we need to find compromises that work for both of us.

Interviewer: And how often do you have these kinds of discussions or conflicts?

Interviewee: Well, for example, discussing how we would handle it if we had a child?

Interviewer: Yes, daily conflicts. How often do you have serious discussions or arguments?

Interviewee: Without it being an argument, I'd say maybe twice a week. But we don't argue, you know. For big arguments, apart from vacations, it happens very rarely, it must have been a year.

Interviewer: And when you argue, how do you resolve it?

Interviewee: That's a problem of mine, I think. Well, basically, she reproaches me for... actually, I'm terrible at communication, initially, so I've learned a lot from her, but conflict paralyzes me; as soon as there's a conflict, I freeze, and I can't do anything, so she reproaches me for always coming back to me during conflicts, and I can't do it. I know it sucks, and I need to work on it, but... it's her who... takes a step towards me to restart the discussion, then it's resolved by talking, generally by mutually apologizing and recognizing our faults, and it's not easy. She has a bit of trouble doing that.

Interviewer: And besides talking and taking a step towards each other, what other ways do you maintain your relationship?

Interviewee: Well, always sharing our lives. So either sending each other messages during the day if something happens, or if we don't have time, telling each other in the evening on the phone, when we see each other, sharing what we experience. And otherwise, we also try to set aside time, we tell ourselves we'll have dates where we reserve time because we both have quite hectic lives, so we try at least once a week to dedicate time to just the two of us. Actually,

there's the thing of reserving at least one evening or one day on the weekend to really spend time together, talking... And then, the date moments, we flirt, we try to seduce each other a bit.

Interviewer: Maintaining a flame, kind of like in the beginning.

Interviewee: Yeah, well, it's never like in the beginning, that's for sure, but there you go. Just saying that we take that time for us, for our love. And otherwise, also often small attentions... I didn't really have the reflex before, but little gifts, little cute things...

Interviewer: Attentions.

Interviewee: Little attentions, yes. Silly things.

Interviewer: And without transition, I'd like to know what could make you leave your partner.

Interviewee: Wow. Uh... honestly, I think nothing, well, I think there are things but she would never do them. For example, if I found out she hadn't been honest about who she was, about her feelings, and I discovered something she had hidden from me, but I'm sure she doesn't do that. Honestly... yeah no, well, also realizing that I don't feel good with her anymore, and that I really have no feelings left, and that... to the point where I have a real aversion to her, but I don't see why that would happen. Or if I also had feelings for someone else and we couldn't manage that together, and for example, I wanted to respond to those feelings, and [PARTNER] wouldn't accept it.

Interviewer: But for you, these are things that are not current and even seem impossible.

Interviewee: Well, the first thing I mentioned, I think it's impossible, but the thing about suddenly having strong feelings for someone else... I doubt we couldn't deal with it together. I think it could always happen... but unlikely. I think we would find a way to handle it so that it goes well.

Interviewer: Okay. Next, would you say this relationship is good for you?

Interviewee: Yeah, totally. 100%.

Interviewer: Does [PARTNER] help you achieve your goals? Do you have examples?

Interviewee: Yeah, I have quite a few examples. First of all, she's a huge support in everything, my whole life. Whether it's work, my family life... Also, I think I'm a better person since I've been with her because I find she has a way of life... I find she's... at least she has a healthy way of life, and she's honest with herself and in all her relationships, and I think that influences me. Then, I've learned a lot about communication, about how... I think she helped me a lot to get out of a period when I was a bit depressed. And also, I used to drink quite a bit of alcohol, go out a lot, smoke a lot of cannabis, and I feel she helped me get out of that, out of those vices. And then, she always encourages me in everything. She helped me accept myself as I am. Especially concerning my gender identity, where initially... when we started being together, I

was beginning to realize I was in a non-binary period, and she supported me well with that and helped me accept it. I feel like a better person.

Interviewer: So, in summary. I feel like she lifts you up, so to speak, and also helps you on a personal development level.

Interviewee: Yes.

Interviewer: Do you think you're the same person as before? Could you elaborate on how this relationship has changed you, or do you think you've already said everything?

Interviewee: Well, I've mentioned the main things: being in tune with myself, communicating better, which has influenced all my friendships, then... my gender identity, all that.

Interviewer: And do you think, conversely, that [PARTNER] has changed during your relationship compared to before?

Interviewee: Yeah, definitely, but more on... less on who she is... Well, first of all, she's worked a lot on her anxieties and fear of abandonment, she says she feels better. And then, otherwise, she's changed in some aspects... When we met, she used to go out more... Before, she used to wear more makeup, it's a silly example, but I think she paid more attention to others' opinions, but I think she has more confidence now. Otherwise, before, she used to go out more, party more, she had more social life but superficial, now she tries to have fewer relationships but more qualitative. Before, she felt that without drinking alcohol and without going out, she would be less cool, well, she still feels that sometimes, but I reassure her.

Interviewer: I see. Do you feel safe in this relationship?

Interviewee: Yeah, totally.

Interviewer: By safety, I mean, of course, physical but also emotional safety, feeling free to express everything: your thoughts and your identity.

Interviewee: Yes!

Interviewer: Now, I'd like us to quickly address another dimension that's part of couple relationships, so sexuality. But we know it can be a more or less important dimension in the relationship. What's it like for you?

Interviewee: Well, we've evolved a lot on this question. Basically, what it is is that we've already accepted that... having sex often is not a prerequisite for a good relationship. During the period when I was depressed, I had no desire for sex, so we went through long periods without sex. It was a topic of discussion at the beginning; she needed to be reassured that I loved her despite not having sexual desire. I reassured her and explained that I didn't feel like it. It took a long time to dissociate the quality of the relationship and the love we have from sexual relations. After that, it's still something we don't talk much about with friends, friends who are in long-term

relationships. Do people really have sex every other day? So after that, I think... I don't have a huge need for sex. She, I think, a bit more but not that much either. We prioritize intimacy, cuddling, we still have the intimacy of sleeping naked, loving each other's bodies, but without necessarily having sex. We've also accepted that, basically, masturbating separately if one of us wants sex only, it's more often her and not me.

Interviewer: So, would you say that this form of sex life satisfies you?

Interviewee: Well yeah, definitely, totally. I think that in my life I forced myself a lot to have these relations because it was important to show that the relationship was going well, but we were in a huge construction. And by deconstructing, I realize that I don't really want that.

Interviewer: You would estimate the frequency of your sexual relations to be how much?

Interviewee: Well, for example, for the past few months, I've had a lot of desire for her and I want to have sex, but the thing is with our lives... in the evening, I'm so tired, I just want to sleep. When your head has problems, my dad is very sick, I'm with him, I come back to see [PARTNER] and I don't feel like having sex at all. And otherwise, for frequency, honestly... it depends on the periods, but in daily life, I'd say not even once every [1-5] months.

Interviewer: Yes, that's it. I feel like it's still heavily impacted by work, fatigue, all the obligations.

Interviewee: Yes. And honestly, since the beginning of [Year], we've had sex maybe twice.

Interviewer: Okay, okay. Next, if I show you a scale, from 1 to 9, knowing that 1 is "Not at all true" and 9 "Completely true." If I asked you, "in general, [PARTNER] really listens to me," what would your answer be?

Interviewee: Uh... 7.

Interviewer: 7.

Interviewee: No, really, I'm exaggerating, 8.

Interviewer: And why eight?

Interviewee: Because when she listens to me, she really listens, but I won't give it a 9 because there are times when she's on her phone, and I ask a silly question, it would take two seconds, and she won't even answer.

Interviewer: And why not 7 then?

Interviewee: Because it's rare. It's just this little thing. It doesn't happen often, and it's silly things. Otherwise, she really listens to me all the time.

Interviewer: Okay. And on the contrary, would you have examples of times when you really felt listened to? Recently, for example.

Interviewee: Well, all the time. This morning, I just saw my dad at the hospital... she's always asking how I feel. She always makes sure I'm okay. And even if I'm fine, she wants to know how I really feel, all that. And listens to the answer.

Interviewer: Yes. And if I asked you, still on a scale of 1 to 9, "Generally, [PARTNER] listens to my needs."

Interviewee: (...) same, I'm hesitating between 7 and 8. It's hard. I don't know, 7.

Interviewer: Same. Could you tell me why 7, and not 6 or 8?

Interviewee: She's very attentive, and why not 8? Hmm, I could have said 8. Really, I'll say 8.

Interviewer: So, same answer. Do you have examples?

Interviewee: Well... all the time when we make decisions, it's about asking what we want, I don't put 9 because there are moments... for example when we're not doing well. And then there are moments, too, where... I don't know.

Interviewer: And generally, how satisfied are you with your relationship among the following answers? "Completely dissatisfied, very dissatisfied, somewhat dissatisfied, neutral, and conversely, somewhat satisfied, very satisfied, completely satisfied."

Interviewee: Completely satisfied.

Interviewer: Could you tell me why?

Interviewee: Well... honestly, for everything we said before.

Interviewer: So, we're about to wrap up. I just have a few demographic questions left. How old are you?

Interviewee: [26-30] years old.

Interviewer: And who lives in your household?

Interviewee: Me.

Interviewer: And what's the household income?

Interviewee: [Amount] net per month.